PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY • PAPER 2 OPTION B4

EARLY ELIZABETHAN ENGLAND

1558–1588 • Queen, Government & Religion • Challenges Home & Abroad • Elizabethan Society & Exploration



Plate I: The Armada Portrait of Queen Elizabeth I (1588). Commemorating the defeat of the Spanish invasion fleet; Elizabeth rests her hand upon the global sphere, flanked by the English naval triumph. Woburn Abbey Collection.

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW • 1558–1588 — **MONARCHY, RELIGION & EMPIRE**

Ascending the throne in November 1558 amidst religious tumult, crippling Crown debt of £300,000, and foreign encirclement by France and Scotland, twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth Tudor established a durable Protestant state. Her 1559 Religious Settlement crafted an enduring political compromise between Catholic traditionalism and Calvinist zeal, establishing the English monarch as Supreme Governor of the Church of England while preserving political order across thirty precarious years.

Yet her reign was fiercely tested by domestic rebellion and geopolitical crisis. The flight of Mary, Queen of Scots ignited northern Catholic insurrections, papal excommunication, and deadly assassination conspiracies, while maritime privateering by Francis Drake escalated into outright war with the superpower of Europe—Philip II's Spain. Culminating in the cataclysmic defeat of the 1588 Spanish Armada, this master textbook provides an authoritative 28-page narrative tracing how Elizabeth secured her realm and forged an oceanic Golden Age.

KT 1 Queen, Government & Religion (1558–69) • KT 2 Challenges Home & Abroad (1569–88) • KT 3 Elizabethan Society & Exploration (1558–88)

COURSE SPECIFICATION & DISCIPLINARY DIRECTORY

FULL SYLLABUS ALIGNMENT ACROSS ALL 12 CANONICAL LESSONS (KEY TOPICS 1–3) • OPTION B4

OFFICIAL SPECIFICATION ALIGNMENT

KEY TOPIC 1 QUEEN, GOVERNMENT AND RELIGION, 1558–69

KT 1.1 The Situation on Elizabeth's Accession

Spread 1 • pp. 4–5

Ascending the throne in 1558, Elizabeth governed a deeply stratified **society and government**. *Her rule was shadowed by fierce questions regarding her* **legitimacy, gender, marriage**, *yet she possessed formidable intelligence. Elizabeth immediately confronted dangerous structural challenges at home and abroad: acute Crown* **financial weaknesses, religious divisions**, *and the imminent* **French threat** *from Scotland.*

KT 1.2 The 'Settlement' of Religion

Spread 2 • pp. 6–7

To reconcile a fractured nation, Elizabeth enacted the historic **religious settlement (1559)**, *establishing the middle way via the Act of Supremacy and Act of Uniformity with its Royal Injunctions. The newly reformed* **Church of England** *asserted its central role in society, enforcing national conformity, preaching royal obedience, and conducting village parish administration across England.*

KT 1.3 Challenge to the Religious Settlement

Spread 3 • pp. 8–9

The middle way faced aggressive opposition from two extremes. The activist **Puritan challenge** *demanded the eradication of all popish vestments and crucifixes. Concurrently, a dangerous* **Catholic challenge** *gathered momentum, sustained by traditional Northern nobility, Jesuit missionary infiltration, and external encouragement from the* **Papacy and foreign powers** *like Spain and Catholic France.*

KT 1.4 The Problem of Mary, Queen of Scots

Spread 4 • pp. 10–11

Fleeing Scottish rebellion in 1568, Catholic cousin **Mary, Queen of Scots** *arrived in England, possessing a potent dynastic* **claim to the English throne** *that attracted disaffected nobles. Delicate relations between* **Elizabeth and Mary, 1568–69** *deteriorated into permanent house arrest, as Elizabeth wrestled with the profound danger of executing an anointed monarch.*

KEY TOPIC 2 CHALLENGES TO ELIZABETH AT HOME AND ABROAD, 1569–88

KT 2.1 Plots and Revolts at Home

Spread 5 • pp. 12–13

Northern Catholic grievances erupted in the **Revolt of the Northern Earls, 1569–70**. *Subsequent foreign-backed conspiracies—the* **Ridolfi, Throckmorton and Babington plots**—*sought Elizabeth's assassination, but were systematically dismantled by Sir Francis* **Walsingham and the use of spies**, *directly culminating in the dramatic trial and* **Mary Queen of Scots' execution in 1587**.

KT 2.2 Relations with Spain

Spread 6 • pp. 14–15

Mounting geopolitical friction ignited deep political, religious and commercial **rivalry** *between Tudor England and Philip II's global empire. Protestant-Catholic antagonism intersected with illicit English trade in the Caribbean, where licensed state* **privateering** *and the lucrative plundering* **activities of Drake** *seizing Spanish silver fleets brought the two powers to the brink of open war.*

KT 2.3 Outbreak of War with Spain, 1585–88

Spread 7 • pp. 16–17

Relations collapsed following direct military intervention in the Spanish **Netherlands** *under the 1585 Treaty of Nonsuch and the controversial actions of* **Robert Dudley**, *Earl of Leicester. War became overt in 1587 when Sir Francis* **Drake** *executed the daring naval* **raid on Cadiz**, *destroying vital supplies in the famous 'Singeing the King of Spain's beard'.*

KT 2.4 The Armada

Spread 8 • pp. 18–19

Philip II launched colossal **invasion plans** *in 1588 to transport Parma's veteran army across the Channel. Through tactical blunders and English fire-ships at Gravelines, the key events of the* **Spanish Armada** *resulted in disaster. Decisive reasons for the* **English victory** *included superior gunnery, Drake's nimble galleons, defensive communications, and catastrophic North Sea storms.*

KEY TOPIC 3 ELIZABETHAN SOCIETY IN THE AGE OF EXPLORATION, 1558–88

KT 3.1 Education and Leisure

Spread 9 • pp. 20–21

Humanist ideas drove an expansion of grammar school **education** *for wealthy boys, literacy, and dame schools, while girls remained confined to domestic tuition. Elizabethan leisure reflected social hierarchy, from violent* **sport, pastimes** *like bear-baiting and hawking to the wildly popular secular flowering of purpose-built public* **theatre** *featuring Marlowe and early Shakespeare.*

KT 3.2 The 'Problem' of the Poor

Spread 10 • pp. 22–23

Bad harvests, population growth, rack-renting, and sheep enclosure caused a alarming increase in **poverty and vagabondage**. *Fear of rural disorder transformed traditional moral condemnation into changing legislative* **attitudes and policies**, *distinguishing between the 'deserving' and 'idle' poor, and establishing local poor rates through landmark Elizabethan Poor Laws.*

KT 3.3 Exploration and Voyages of Discovery

Spread 11 • pp. 24–25

Maritime expansion was propelled by revolutionary **new technology on ships and sailing**, *including the astrolabe, triangular lateen sails, and the commercial drive to* **expand trade** *beyond European cloth markets. National prestige surged with* **Drake's circumnavigation of the globe** *(1577–80), reaping immense plunder and establishing England as a formidable oceanic maritime power.*

KT 3.4 Attempted Colonisation of Virginia

Spread 12 • pp. 26–27

Imperial ambitions motivated the **attempted colonisation of Virginia**, *spearheaded by Sir Walter* **Raleigh** *to challenge Spanish hegemony and establish permanent New World bases. Despite intense royal backing, the* **failure of the first settlement** *at Roanoke resulted from poor planning, hostile Indigenous relations, severe supply starvation, and the complete disappearance of the 'Lost Colony'.*

CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONE SPINE & TURNING POINTS

18 DEFINING CAUSAL TURNING POINTS ACROSS ALL 12 CANONICAL LESSONS • OPTION B4

CHRONOLOGICAL HIGHWAY

17 Nov 1558

Accession of Queen Elizabeth I & Appointment of William Cecil

Following the death of Mary I, twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth Tudor ascends the throne, inheriting £300,000 in debt; Sir William Cecil is appointed Principal Secretary.

8 May 1559

The Elizabethan Religious Settlement Passed by Parliament

The Act of Supremacy establishes Elizabeth as "Supreme Governor" of the Church of England; the Act of Uniformity imposes the 1559 Book of Common Prayer and 1s recusancy fines.

24 Jun 1559

Royal Injunctions Enforce Uniformity & Church Visitations

Royal Injunctions mandate English liturgy, enforce clerical vestments, ban unauthorized preaching, and initiate nation-wide inspections by royal commissioners.

26 Mar 1566

The Lambeth Vestments Crisis & Archbishop Parker's Advertisements

Archbishop Matthew Parker commands London clergy to wear the surplice; thirty-seven Puritan ministers refuse on grounds of conscience and are stripped of their livings.

16 May 1568

Mary, Queen of Scots Flees into England Across the Solway Firth

Escaping imprisonment at Lochleven following defeat at Langside, Mary Stuart lands at Workington in Cumbria, creating an immediate dynastic crisis for the English Crown.

Oct 1568

The York and Westminster Inquiries Convene over the Casket Letters

Scottish Protestant lords present the mysterious Casket Letters implicating Mary in Lord Darnley's murder; Cecil engineers an inconclusive verdict to detain Mary indefinitely.

Nov 1569

The Revolt of the Northern Earls (The Rising of the North)

The Catholic Earls of Northumberland and Westmorland seize Durham Cathedral, celebrate Catholic Mass, and march south to free Mary Stuart; the rebellion is crushed and 450 rebels executed.

25 Feb 1570

Pope Pius V Issues the Papal Bull Regnans in Excelsis

The Pope excommunicates Elizabeth as a heretic, absolving all Catholic subjects from their oath of allegiance and transforming English Catholics into potential traitors in law.

Mar 1571

The Ridolfi Plot Uncovered by Elizabeth's Intelligence Network

Italian banker Roberto Ridolfi conspires with the Duke of Norfolk and Spain to assassinate Elizabeth; Norfolk is tried for high treason and executed on Tower Hill in 1572.

1572

The Vagabonds Act Introduces Compulsory Parish Poor Rates

Parliament mandates harsh physical punishments (whipping and ear-boring) for idle vagrants while establishing the first statutory compulsory poor relief system administered by JPs.

26 Sep 1580

Francis Drake Completes Global Circumnavigation in the Golden Hind

Drake returns to Plymouth with £400,000 in seized Spanish treasure; Elizabeth defies King Philip II by boarding the Golden Hind at Deptford and knighting Drake in April 1581.

Nov 1583

The Throckmorton Plot Exposed & The Bond of Association Formed

Francis Throckmorton confesses under torture on the rack to a French Catholic invasion plan backed by Spanish money; Council leaders establish the lethal Bond of Association.

1584

Walter Raleigh Granted Royal Patent for North American Colonisation

Elizabeth grants Raleigh a charter to explore and settle unclaimed lands; Arthur Barlowe's expedition scouts Roanoke Island and returns to London praising "Virginia".

20 Aug 1585

The Treaty of Nonsuch Commits English Troops to the Netherlands

Following William of Orange's assassination and the Treaty of Joinville, Elizabeth signs the Treaty of Nonsuch, sending 7,400 soldiers under Leicester, entering direct war with Spain.

Jul 1586

The Babington Plot Intercepted: Walsingham Cracks the Cipher

Sir Francis Walsingham intercepts and deciphers letters hidden in beer barrels between Anthony Babington and Mary Stuart, obtaining Mary's explicit written consent to regicide.

8 Feb 1587

Execution of Mary, Queen of Scots at Fotheringhay Castle

Following parliamentary petitions and Cecil's pressure, Elizabeth signs the death warrant; Mary Stuart is beheaded in the Great Hall, removing the Catholic dynastic figurehead.

19 Apr 1587

Drake's Raid on Cadiz ("Singeing the King of Spain's Beard")

Sir Francis Drake leads an audacity-fueled preemptive naval assault on Cadiz harbour, destroying over thirty Spanish warships and burning thousands of seasoned oak barrel staves.

8 Aug 1588

The Battle of Gravelines & The Dispersal of the Spanish Armada

English fireships break the Armada crescent off Calais; race-built galleons batter Spanish hulls at close range; westerly gale winds drive the surviving invasion fleet into the North Sea.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did an inexperienced queen secure an impoverished and divided England amidst acute foreign encirclement in 1558?

[1.1] *1558*

Hatfield Oak to the Tower: Inheriting Bankruptcy and Cecil's Partnership

> ***"Why did inherited debt and foreign loans create a crisis in 1558?"***

In November 1558, twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth Tudor ascended the English throne following the death of her Catholic half-sister Mary I. The young Queen inherited an impoverished, vulnerable realm burdened by an astronomical **£300,000** Crown debt, largely accumulated through costly Tudor wars in France and currency debasement that shook confidence in English coinage. Because the Crown's ordinary annual revenue stood at barely £286,000, royal treasurers were forced to take foreign loans on the **Antwerp** money market at steep 14% interest to fund basic expenditure. Seeking immediate administrative grip and fiscal stability, Elizabeth acted decisively on accession day by appointing Sir **William Cecil** as Principal Secretary, forging a political partnership that directed English statecraft for forty years.

[1.2] *1558*

The Royal Court & Privy Council: Patronage, Factional Flattery and the 19-Man Council

> ***"How did Elizabeth use patronage and factions to control her court?"***

Tudor monarchical rule rested upon divine right, yet the Crown possessed no standing army or salaried national police force. Executive authority was instead exercised through a streamlined 19-man **Privy Council** of trusted nobles and seasoned administrators who met almost daily at court to direct national defence, royal finance, foreign diplomacy, and the enforcement of parliamentary statutes. To preserve political stability, Elizabeth skilfully balanced rival court factions so ambitious councillors like William Cecil and Robert Dudley could never monopolise royal favour or policy. She bound the landed elite firmly to her throne through royal **patronage**, distributing prestigious court offices, Crown land leases, and lucrative commercial **monopolies** that rewarded unswerving political loyalty without surrendering her royal prerogative.

[1.3] *1558*

Challenges of Gender & Marriage: Female Monarchical Rule, Legitimacy and Knox's Opposition

> ***"Why did doubts over gender, marriage, and legitimacy threaten rule?"***

Elizabeth's title was immediately questioned through sixteenth-century patriarchal prejudice against female rulers and religious doubts over her birth. Roman Catholic canon law maintained that Henry VIII's marriage to Catherine of Aragon remained indissoluble, condemning his 1533 wedding to **Anne Boleyn** as invalid; devout Catholics therefore viewed Elizabeth as illegitimate and barred from inheriting the English crown. Doubts were reinforced by Henry VIII's own **1536 Succession Act**, passed after Anne Boleyn's execution, which had legally declared Elizabeth illegitimate even after the 1544 Act restored her place in line. As an unmarried queen regnant, she faced relentless parliamentary pressure to marry and produce a **Protestant heir** lest sudden illness plunge England into dynastic civil war.

[1.4] *1559*

Whitehall to the Shires: Reluctant Parliaments and Unpaid Country JPs

> ***"Why did the Crown rely on Parliament and unpaid local gentry?"***

Beyond Whitehall, the Tudor Crown depended entirely upon unpaid county elites to enforce royal authority across the shires. Regional defence was entrusted to noble **Lords Lieutenant**, who mustered and trained county militias during emergencies, while daily local government rested on wealthy gentry appointed as **Justices of the Peace** to judge crimes, maintain roads, and administer poor laws. Meanwhile, **Parliament** was not a permanent legislature but an occasional assembly summoned only when the monarch needed new statutes or emergency war funding. Although Elizabeth fiercely guarded her royal prerogative over marriage, religion, and foreign policy, constitutional custom dictated that extraordinary taxation required parliamentary consent, giving the House of Commons important financial leverage.

[1.5] *1558–1560*

The Catholic Pincer: The Surrender of Calais and French Troops on the Tweed

> ***"Why did losing Calais and the Auld Alliance create encirclement?"***

In foreign affairs, Elizabeth inherited dangerous strategic encirclement by hostile Catholic powers. During Mary I's disastrous French war alongside Habsburg Spain, England had suffered the humiliating loss of **Calais** in January 1558—its last continental foothold—damaging Tudor military prestige and leaving England's southern coastline exposed to invasion fleets assembling across the narrow English Channel. Danger was compounded to the north through France's traditional **Auld Alliance** with Scotland, where veteran French garrison troops bolstered Regent Mary of Guise along the vulnerable English border. Her daughter, Catholic claimant **Mary, Queen of Scots**, was married to the French Dauphin Francis and quartered the English royal arms with her own, openly asserting her dynastic claim to Elizabeth's throne.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Executive Institutionalisation • Factional Patronage and Cecil's Bureaucratic Partnership**

Elizabeth overcame the structural weakness of inherited bankruptcy and patriarchal prejudice by balancing rival court factions and binding the aristocracy through royal patronage.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

To what extent was the 1559 Religious Settlement an enduring theological compromise designed to prevent civil war?

[2.1] *1558–1559*

A Fractured Realm: Marian Burnings, Geneva Exiles and the Search for Peace

"Why did England's religious divisions require a cautious compromise?"

Upon her accession in 1558, Elizabeth inherited a deeply fractured nation scarred by decades of sudden Tudor religious upheaval. Conservative **northern gentry** and earls in the north and west remained devoted to traditional Roman Catholic Mass, images, and papal authority, whereas London, East Anglia, and south-eastern ports strongly favoured Protestant reform through continental trade links. Following Mary I's burning of nearly three hundred Protestants, zealous **Marian exiles** returned from Calvinist Geneva and Zurich demanding a stripped, scripture-only church purged of every Catholic remnant. Conversely, twenty-six conservative **Marian bishops** sat in the House of Lords opposing Protestant legislation, forcing Elizabeth to craft a cautious religious compromise to avert sectarian civil war.

[2.2] *1559*

The Crown Restored: The Act of Supremacy and the Title of Supreme Governor

"Why did Elizabeth adopt the title 'Supreme Governor' under Supremacy?"

Passed by Parliament in May 1559, the **Act of Supremacy** permanently severed England's legal ties with Rome and restored royal control over the Church. In a shrewd diplomatic gesture designed to calm Catholic consciences—and ease male anxieties over a woman heading the Church—Elizabeth adopted the title **Supreme Governor** rather than Henry VIII's 'Supreme Head'. The statute introduced a mandatory **Oath of Supremacy**, requiring all clergy, judges, university fellows, and royal officeholders to swear allegiance to Elizabeth's spiritual authority or forfeit their posts. While twenty-six of twenty-seven Marian bishops refused and were deprived of their sees, roughly 8,000 ordinary parish priests took the oath, giving the new Protestant hierarchy peaceful continuity.

[2.3] *1559*

The Altar of Compromise: The Act of Uniformity, Liturgy and One-Shilling Recusancy

"How did the Act of Uniformity balance Protestant and Catholic worship?"

Enacted alongside royal supremacy, the May 1559 **Act of Uniformity** established a single legal pattern of worship across every parish in England and Wales. It introduced a revised English **Book of Common Prayer** and required everyone to attend church every Sunday and holy day; absentees were classed as **recusants** and fined twelve pence (one shilling) per missed service. To win broad acceptance, the prayer book deliberately fused the 1549 and 1552 communion sentences so traditionalists could perceive Christ's real presence in the bread and wine while Protestants understood it as a memorial meal. Meanwhile, the Ornaments Rubric retained traditional clerical vestments and church decoration, reassuring conservative rural congregations with familiar outward dignity.

[2.4] *1559*

The Royal Injunctions: Crucifix Bans, Clerical Surplices and Church Visitations

> ***"How did the 57 Royal Injunctions regulate local parish worship?"***

In the summer of 1559, William Cecil issued fifty-seven **Royal Injunctions**—detailed practical instructions guiding parish clergy on how to implement the statutory religious settlement in local communities. Every licensed minister had to preach royal supremacy at least four times a year, denounce papal superstition, and place a large **English Bible** alongside Erasmus's *Paraphrases* inside every parish church. The injunctions outlawed traditional Catholic **pilgrimages**, 'feigned' miracles, candles burned before statues, and processions around monuments while permitting traditional hymns and kneeling at prayer for Christian reverence. Clerical marriage was permitted for Protestant priests, provided prospective wives produced formal certificates of good character approved by the diocesan bishop and two local Justices of the Peace.

[2.5] *1559–1560s*

The Pulpit of the Realm: Church Courts, Royal Homilies and Community Feasts

> ***"How did visitations and the Church of England enforce daily order?"***

To police religious compliance nationwide, the Crown appointed 125 royal commissioners to conduct sweeping **visitations** across every English and Welsh diocese in autumn 1559, inspecting parish altars, removing superstitious images, administering the Oath of Supremacy, and licensing loyal preachers. Only around **400 clergy** resigned or were dismissed nationwide, allowing most rural parishes to transition smoothly under familiar local vicars. Beyond Sunday liturgy, the established Church of England underpinned everyday village order, poor relief, and royal obedience. Ecclesiastical **Church courts** supervised community morality by prosecuting slander, adultery, sabbath-breaking, heresy, and disputed wills, while elected parish churchwardens collected alms and vicars read royal proclamations aloud from the pulpit to a largely illiterate rural population.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **The Via Media Compromise • Deliberate Doctrinal Ambiguity and Monarchical Supremacy**

By adopting the title Supreme Governor and blending Protestant liturgy with traditional ceremonial vestments, Elizabeth established state control while averting violent religious civil strife.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did ideological opposition from Puritan zealots and Catholic traditionalists threaten Elizabeth's middle way in the 1560s?

[3.1] *1559–1563*

The Puritan Challenge: Beliefs, Demands and the Crucifix Controversy

> ***"Why did Puritan demands over crucifixes challenge royal authority?"***

Radical Protestant reformers known as **Puritans** viewed Elizabeth's 1559 settlement as a lukewarm compromise tainted by popish ceremony. Inspired by John Calvin's Geneva, returning Marian exiles campaigned to strip parish churches of organs, stained glass, holy days, and silver **crucifix** ornaments—forcing Elizabeth to remove the silver crucifix from her own Royal Chapel when newly appointed Protestant bishops threatened to resign. At the **1563 Convocation** of clergy, Puritan reformers came within a single vote of abolishing kneeling at communion, saints' feast days, and organ music altogether. Elizabeth regarded such clerical activism as a direct assault on her royal prerogative as Supreme Governor, insisting that once Parliament had settled worship, subjects owed silent obedience.

[3.2] *1566*

The Vestments Controversy: Archbishop Parker, the Surplice Dispute and Puritan Defiance

> ***"How did Archbishop Parker defeat Puritan defiance over vestments?"***

Clerical resistance peaked in the mid-1560s over traditional priestly vestments. Zealous Puritans refused to wear the plain white linen **surplice** and square cap prescribed by the Ornaments Rubric, condemning special priestly garments as 'rags of Rome'. Determined to enforce outward uniformity, Elizabeth ordered Archbishop of Canterbury **Matthew Parker** to issue his 1566 **Book of Advertisements** setting strict rules for clerical dress. When Parker summoned 110 London ministers to Lambeth Palace in March 1566 to inspect compliant model outfits, **37 Puritan priests** refused to conform and were promptly suspended and deprived of their church livings. Lacking noble military backing or any viable Protestant alternative to Elizabeth, most remaining Puritans grudgingly wore the surplice rather than lose their parish pulpits.

[3.3] *1559–1568*

The Catholic Stronghold: Northern Magnates, Manor Altars and Church Papists

> ***"Why did most English Catholics conform outwardly in the early 1560s?"***

Domestic Catholic opposition initially remained subdued and largely passive during the early 1560s. Thousands of traditionalists acted as **Church Papists**, attending Anglican parish services on Sundays to escape the twelve-penny recusancy fine while hearing Latin Mass privately inside gentry manor houses whenever opportunity arose, especially across northern shires where sympathetic Catholic earls and lax local JPs ignored recusancy. Elizabeth reinforced domestic calm by refusing to make 'windows into men's souls' so long as Catholic subjects stayed politically loyal, while Pope Pius IV issued no immediate excommunication against her. By 1566–68, however, the militant European **Counter-Reformation** hardened attitudes: **Pope Pius V** forbade English Catholics from attending Protestant church services and William Allen founded the Douai seminary.

[3.4] *1562–1568*

The Counter-Reformation Shadow: Alba's Tercios, Douai Seminaries and the Jesuit Mission

> ***"Why did Alba's Spanish army in the Netherlands alarm the Privy Council?"***

Abroad, escalating European religious conflict reshaped England's strategic security. When the **French Wars of Religion** erupted in 1562, Elizabeth briefly sent money and troops to aid French Huguenot Protestants in hopes of regaining Calais, though English defeat at Le Havre ended the venture under the 1564 Treaty of Troyes while keeping France too divided internally to threaten England. Far graver strategic danger emerged across the narrow sea in the Spanish Netherlands. In 1567 Catholic King Philip II dispatched the ruthless **Duke of Alba** with 10,000 veteran Spanish troops to crush Dutch Protestant protests and heresy. Alba established the notorious **Council of Troubles** ('Council of Blood'), executing thousands of Dutch Protestants and stationing a battle-hardened Catholic army just across the Channel.

[3.5] *1568–1569*

The Genoese Loan: Spanish Silver, Trade Embargoes and the Edge of War

> ***"How did seizing the Genoese Loan strain relations with Catholic Spain?"***

In November 1568, Anglo-Spanish friction escalated sharply when five Spanish vessels carrying **£85,000** in gold bullion borrowed from Italian bankers took shelter in Plymouth and Southampton from Channel storms and French privateers. The treasure—known as the **Genoese Loan**—was urgently bound for Antwerp to pay the Duke of Alba's Spanish army operating in the Netherlands. Advised by William Cecil to weaken Spanish military power in Flanders, Elizabeth audaciously impounded the bullion on the legal technicality that the gold still belonged to Genoese bankers until safely delivered to Antwerp, transferring the loan to the English Crown instead. Outraged, Alba seized English merchant ships and imposed a punishing **Antwerp trade embargo**, paralysing London cloth exports.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Confessional Polarisation • The Radicalisation of Conscience and Foreign Geopolitical Pressure**

The Elizabethan settlement was squeezed between uncompromising Calvinists demanding total reformation and traditionalists sustained by continental Catholic armies and Douai seminaries.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did the arrival of Mary, Queen of Scots in 1568 transform Elizabeth's dynastic security into a permanent national crisis?

[4.1] *1560–1565*

Two Anointed Queens: The Scottish Succession, Bloodline Rivalry and the French Pincer

"Why did Mary Stuart's Tudor bloodline threaten Elizabeth's throne?"

In May 1568, the unexpected arrival of Catholic **Mary, Queen of Scots** in Cumbria confronted Elizabeth with an acute dynastic emergency. As the Catholic granddaughter of Henry VIII's elder sister **Margaret Tudor**, Mary possessed an unimpeachable legitimate Tudor bloodline, making her the natural heir presumptive—and in strict Catholic eyes, England's rightful reigning monarch. Unlike unmarried Elizabeth, Mary had already given birth to a healthy male heir, Prince **James VI**, in June 1566 after marrying her cousin Henry Stuart, Lord Darnley. Even as a penniless fugitive stripped of her Scottish crown, Mary immediately became a dangerous political magnet for disaffected English Catholic nobles hoping to topple Cecil and restore Roman Catholicism.

[4.2] *1567*

Kirk o' Field: Gunpowder Treason, Bothwell's Ambition and Darnley's Murder

"How did Darnley's murder at Kirk o' Field destroy Mary's rule?"

Mary's Scottish reign had collapsed amidst sensational aristocratic violence in Edinburgh. Deeply resentful of her drunken, violent second husband **Lord Darnley**—who had helped murder her Italian secretary David Rizzio before her eyes—Mary was implicated when a massive gunpowder explosion destroyed Darnley's lodging at **Kirk o' Field** in February 1567 and Darnley was found strangled outside in the orchard. Only three months later, Mary scandalised royal courts across Europe by marrying the chief murder suspect, the ruthless **Earl of Bothwell**. Outraged Protestant Scottish lords rose in armed rebellion, confronted Mary's dwindling forces at Carberry Hill in June 1567, drove Bothwell into Scandinavian exile, and paraded a humiliated Mary back through hostile Edinburgh crowds.

[4.3] *1567–1568*

Lochleven to the Solway: Abdication, Island Dungeon and Mary's Desperate Flight

"Why did Mary's escape from Lochleven into England trap Elizabeth?"

Imprisoned on an island fortress at **Lochleven** Castle in July 1567, Mary was forced by rebel Protestant lords to abdicate in favour of her one-year-old son James VI under the regency of her Protestant half-brother, the **Earl of Moray**. In May 1568 Mary escaped Lochleven, raised 6,000 supporters, lost at Langside, and fled by fishing boat across the Solway Firth into England. Mary's arrival trapped Elizabeth in an acute diplomatic dilemma. Sending English troops to restore a deposed Catholic monarch would alienate friendly Protestant Scotland; handing Mary back risked executing an anointed sovereign; allowing her abroad risked French military intervention; keeping her under **house arrest** inside England invited endless domestic Catholic plots.

[4.4] *1568–1569*

The York Inquiry: The Mysterious Casket Letters and Cecil's Stalemate

> *"Why did the York Inquiry over the Casket Letters end without a verdict?"*

Seeking to discredit Mary politically without putting a fellow anointed monarch on criminal trial, Elizabeth convened a formal commission of inquiry at **York** (later moved south to Westminster) between October 1568 and January 1569. Scottish Regent Moray dramatically produced eight French **Casket Letters** and love sonnets allegedly written by Mary to Bothwell proving she had plotted Darnley's assassination. Mary's representatives condemned the letters as Protestant rebel forgeries and demanded she address Elizabeth face-to-face, which Elizabeth flatly refused. In January 1569 William Cecil delivered a calculated **not proven verdict**: neither clearing Moray of treasonous rebellion nor pronouncing Mary innocent, thereby giving Elizabeth a convenient diplomatic pretext to hold Mary captive indefinitely.

[4.5] *1569*

The Gilded Cage: Bolton Castle, Northern Vigilance and the Threat to Whitehall

> *"How did Mary's captivity spark the 1569 Norfolk marriage conspiracy?"*

In early 1569 Elizabeth transferred Mary south to Tutbury Castle and Sheffield Manor under the watchful, expensive custody of George Talbot, **Earl of Shrewsbury**. Despite strict surveillance, Mary's continued captivity inside England immediately inspired an aristocratic **court marriage plot** backed secretly by courtiers including Robert Dudley, who hoped marrying Mary to an English Protestant peer would settle the succession. The chosen groom was England's wealthiest premier peer, Thomas Howard, **Duke of Norfolk**. When the Catholic Earls of Northumberland and Westmorland widened the secret scheme toward toppling Cecil and restoring Catholicism—and a terrified Dudley confessed everything to a furious Elizabeth in September 1569—Norfolk was clapped into the Tower, igniting northern rebellion.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Dynastic Entrapment • The Legitimate Catholic Alternative and Sovereign Impasse**

As Henry VII's great-granddaughter and an anointed Catholic sovereign, Mary's presence on English soil created an inescapable focal point for Catholic rebellion and foreign invasion.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did escalating assassination conspiracies compel Elizabeth to take the unprecedented step of executing an anointed monarch?

[5.1] *1569–1570*

The Northern Fire: Catholic Earls, Durham Cathedral and Tudor Vengeance

> ***"Why did the Revolt of the Northern Earls fail to depose Elizabeth?"***

Following Norfolk's arrest, the **Northern Earls**—Catholic magnates Thomas Percy, Earl of Northumberland, and Charles Neville, Earl of Westmorland—launched an armed uprising in November 1569 to rescue Mary Stuart from Tutbury and restore Catholicism. Marching 4,600 men into **Durham Cathedral**, rebels tore up the English Bible and prayer book and celebrated a defiant Latin Mass. However, promised Spanish troops from Alba never landed at Hartlepool, most loyal northern gentry stood by the Queen, and Elizabeth moved Mary south to Coventry before dispatching a large royal army under the Earl of Sussex. As the earls fled into Scotland, Elizabeth ordered **450 rebels executed** under martial law across northern villages and confiscated rebel estates under the reconstituted Council of the North.

[5.2] *1570–1572*

Regnans in Excelsis & The Ridolfi Conspiracy: Intercepted Ciphers and Norfolk's Axe

> ***"How did the 1570 Papal Bull and Ridolfi Plot endanger the Queen?"***

Too late to rally support for the northern rebels, Pope Pius V issued the papal bull **Regnans in Excelsis** in February 1570, formally excommunicating Elizabeth as a heretic and commanding English Catholics to end their allegiance to her. Overnight, every devout English Catholic became a potential traitor in Parliament's eyes, prompting the harsh **1571 Treasons Act** outlawing papal bulls. In 1571 Italian-born Florentine banker Roberto Ridolfi organised the international **Ridolfi Plot**: Philip II promised 10,000 Spanish troops under Alba to invade England, assassinate Elizabeth, and place Mary Stuart on the throne married to Norfolk. Cecil and Walsingham intercepted Ridolfi's coded letters, leading directly to the **Duke of Norfolk**'s execution for high treason in June 1572.

[5.3] *1583–1584*

The Jesuit Shadow & Throckmorton's Confession: The Rack and the Bond of Association

> ***"Why did the Throckmorton Plot produce the Bond of Association?"***

As Jesuit and seminary priests trained at Douai smuggled themselves into England after 1574—leading to Edmund Campion's execution and £20 monthly recusancy fines in 1581—Secretary of State **Sir Francis Walsingham** uncovered the **Throckmorton Plot** in November 1583. Under torture, courier Francis Throckmorton confessed a plan for Mary's cousin, the French Catholic Duke of Guise, to invade Sussex. Crucially, Spain's London ambassador Bernardino de Mendoza was financing the conspiracy with Spanish gold; Elizabeth expelled Mendoza, severing formal diplomatic ties with Madrid. To deter future plots, Cecil and Walsingham created the 1584 **Bond of Association** (enacted into law in 1585), binding signatories to execute anyone on whose behalf an assassination of Elizabeth was attempted.

[5.4] *1586*

The Beer Barrel Cryptograms: Walsingham's Trap and Babington's Fatal Sign-Off

> ***"How did Walsingham's beer-barrel cipher trap expose Babington and Mary?"***

In 1586 young Derbyshire Catholic gentleman Anthony Babington organised the **Babington Plot** to murder Elizabeth at court, rescue Mary Stuart from Chartley Hall in Staffordshire, and trigger a joint Franco-Spanish Catholic invasion of 60,000 troops backed financially by the Pope. Unknown to Mary, Walsingham's Catholic double agent Gilbert Gifford routed every coded letter smuggled inside **beer barrels** directly to Walsingham's desk. Master codebreaker **Thomas Phelippes** patiently deciphered every message until, on 17 July 1586, Mary dictated a reply explicitly endorsing the 'dispatch' (assassination) of Elizabeth before foreign troops landed. Phelippes forged a postscript requesting the six assassins' names, enabling Walsingham to arrest Babington, execute the conspirators horribly, and seize Mary's incriminating papers.

[5.5] *1587*

The Great Hall at Fotheringhay: The Regicide Dilemma and Mary's Red Execution

> ***"Why was Mary Stuart's execution at Fotheringhay so significant?"***

Put on trial before thirty-six royal commissioners at **Fotheringhay Castle** in October 1586 under the 1585 Act for the Preservation of the Queen's Safety, Mary was swiftly convicted of high treason. Still agonising over executing an anointed queen and provoking Spanish or Scottish retaliation, Elizabeth delayed until February 1587 before signing the death warrant, which her Privy Council secretly dispatched. On **8 February 1587**, forty-four-year-old Mary knelt in the Great Hall at Fotheringhay wearing bright **crimson martyrdom** petticoats—the liturgical colour of Catholic martyrs. Although Scottish King James VI accepted Elizabeth's tearful apology, Mary had bequeathed her claim to England to Philip II, removing the domestic Catholic figurehead while hardening Spain's resolve to invade.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Preemptive Surveillance • Cryptanalysis, Agent Provocateurs, and State Security Law**

Faced with papal excommunication and systematic assassination plots, Walsingham's intelligence apparatus weaponised intercepted ciphers to force the execution of Mary Stuart.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did maritime raiding and covert proxy intervention escalate an undeclared cold war into direct military conflict with Spain?

[6.1] *1570–1577*

The Spanish Superpower: Philip II's Empire, the Dutch Revolt and English Sympathy

> ***"Why did Spanish rule in the Netherlands threaten English security?"***

Throughout the 1570s, Anglo-Spanish relations deteriorated steadily over religious, commercial, and strategic rivalry in the **Spanish Netherlands**. Because Low Countries Channel ports lay directly opposite the Thames estuary and Antwerp dominated English woollen cloth exports, Elizabeth dreaded Spanish absolutism crushing traditional Dutch provincial liberties and establishing a permanent Catholic military springboard facing southern England. When Dutch Protestants led by **William of Orange** rebelled against Alba's harsh taxation and religious persecution, Elizabeth avoided open war while covertly sending secret loans, permitting English Protestant volunteers to fight, and briefly sheltering Dutch **Sea Beggars** before expelling them from English ports in 1572—an expulsion that ironically prompted them to seize Brielle and ignite general Dutch revolt.

[6.2] *1570–1579*

The Silver Route: John Hawkins, Caribbean Privateering and the Cacafuego Loot

> ***"How did English privateering challenge Spain's New World monopoly?"***

Simultaneously, fierce commercial conflict erupted across the Atlantic as English **privateers** challenged King Philip II's closed imperial monopoly over New World trade. After Spanish warships ambushed John Hawkins and **Francis Drake** at San Juan de Ulúa in 1568, Drake launched daring retaliatory **privateering** raids across the Spanish Main, ambushing silver mule trains at Nombre de Dios in Panama. Rather than punishing her captains, Elizabeth secretly invested royal ships and capital into syndicates licensing legalised maritime plunder against Spanish shipping while issuing polite diplomatic denials to Madrid. After mutinous unpaid Spanish troops sacked Antwerp in the brutal **Spanish Fury** of November 1576, Elizabeth lent the Dutch Estates £100,000 under the Pacification of Ghent.

[6.3] *1577–1580*

The Golden Hind: Drake's Oceanic Voyage, Pacific Plunder and the Plymouth Return

> ***"How did Drake's voyage in the Golden Hind raid Spanish Pacific wealth?"***

In December 1577 Elizabeth secretly backed Drake's expedition of five ships from Plymouth with orders to sail through the Strait of Magellan and raid Spanish Pacific possessions—while publicly claiming he was bound for Alexandria. Surviving fierce Magellan gales in his renamed flagship **Golden Hind**, Drake attacked unfortified Spanish ports up the coasts of Chile and Peru. In March 1579 Drake captured Spain's premier Pacific treasure galleon, nicknamed the **Cacafuego**, seizing over £140,000 in silver bars, gold, and jewels before sailing across the Pacific and Indian oceans. Returning to Plymouth in September 1580 with roughly **£400,000** in total plunder, Drake gave Elizabeth enough Crown share to clear England's entire national debt.

[6.4] *1580–1581*

The Deptford Knighting: Elizabeth's Defiance, Philip's Outrage and the £10,000 Reward

> ***"Why did knighting Drake at Deptford infuriate King Philip II?"***

Furious at Drake's Pacific raids—and newly emboldened after annexing Portugal and its Atlantic war fleet in 1580—King Philip II instructed ambassador Mendoza to demand Drake's immediate execution as a pirate and complete restitution of the captured treasure. Instead, in April 1581 Elizabeth boarded the *Golden Hind* at **Deptford** on the River Thames and publicly awarded **Drake's knighthood** upon the quarterdeck. Deliberately handing the ceremonial gilded sword to a visiting French royal diplomat while courting the Catholic **Duke of Alençon** as a marriage suitor and financing his Dutch intervention, Elizabeth signalled an anti-Spanish alignment with France. Publicly honouring 'El Draque' humiliated Philip II before all Europe, proving the English Crown endorsed maritime challenges to Spain's empire.

[6.5] *1584–1585*

The Alliance Hardens: The French Catholic League, Joinville and the Treaty of Nonsuch

> ***"Why did William of Orange's death and Joinville force Nonsuch (1585)?"***

By 1584 indirect diplomacy collapsed altogether. Under the brilliant Spanish general **Duke of Parma**, Spain steadily reconquered southern Dutch towns; then on 10 July 1584 a Catholic assassin shot dead rebel leader William of Orange at Delft. Worse still, in December 1584 Philip II signed the **Treaty of Joinville** with the French Catholic League to eradicate Protestantism. With France neutralised by Catholic League civil war and Antwerp falling to Parma, Elizabeth could no longer rely on surrogates. On 10 August 1585 she signed the **Treaty of Nonsuch** with the Dutch Protestant Estates, pledging 7,400 English soldiers under Robert Dudley, Earl of Leicester—an act Philip II treated as an open declaration of Anglo-Spanish war.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Asymmetric Maritime Aggression • State-Sanctioned Piracy and Dutch Strategic Buffer Defense**

By backing privateers who raided Spanish treasure routes and knighting Francis Drake in public defiance of Philip II, Elizabeth provoked open war to defend England's geopolitical frontiers.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did direct English military intervention in the Low Countries force Philip II to launch the "Enterprise of England"?

[7.1] *1585–1586*

The Treaty of Nonsuch: Leicester's Expedition and the Defense of Flushing

> ***"Why did Dudley's title of Governor-General anger both Queen and Dutch?"***

Landing in the Netherlands in December 1585 with 7,400 men after England garrisoned the cautionary ports of **Flushing** and Brielle, **Robert Dudley**, Earl of Leicester, immediately enraged Elizabeth in January 1586 by accepting the supreme title **Governor-General** of the United Provinces without consulting her. Furious that accepting sovereignty openly repudiated Philip II's hereditary rule, Elizabeth publicly humiliated Dudley before the Dutch. Throughout 1586–87 Elizabeth deliberately starved the expedition of money, siege artillery, and reinforcements, hoping still to negotiate a compromise peace with Madrid while unpaid English troops suffered hunger and desertion. Even so, Dudley's garrisons slowed the **Duke of Parma**'s coastal advance and held the deep-water port of Ostend, denying Spain an easy Channel anchorage.

[7.2] *1586–1587*

Disaster in the Low Countries: Zutphen, Desertions and Leicester's Resignation

> ***"How did betrayals at Deventer and Zutphen undermine Dudley's campaign?"***

Militarily and politically, Leicester's Dutch campaign suffered demoralising blows. During the autumn 1586 skirmish outside **Zutphen**, celebrated Protestant courtier-poet Sir Philip Sidney was mortally wounded, and in January 1587 two Catholic English officers appointed by Leicester—Sir William Stanley and **Rowland Yorke**—treacherously surrendered the vital town of **Deventer** and Zutphen fort directly to Parma's Spanish army. Stanley and Yorke's shocking defection shattered Dutch confidence in English loyalty, especially as rumours spread of secret Anglo-Spanish peace talks and English privateers disrupted Dutch Baltic shipping. Unable to cooperate smoothly with the merchant-led Dutch States-General or match Parma's 30,000 veteran soldiers, a discredited Dudley was permanently recalled to England by Elizabeth in late 1587.

[7.3] *1587*

Singeing the King of Spain's Beard: Drake's Daring Raid on Cadiz Harbour

> ***"How did Drake's raid on Cadiz disrupt Spain's invasion preparations?"***

Learning from Walsingham's spies in early 1587 that Philip II—spurred by Nonsuch and Mary Stuart's execution—was assembling a vast invasion Armada, Elizabeth ordered Francis Drake to strike pre-emptively against Spanish ports. On 19 April 1587 Drake sailed twenty-four warships boldly into **Cadiz** harbour—Spain's busiest naval arsenal—in a daring raid nicknamed **'Singeing the King of Spain's Beard'**. Over three days of chaotic bombardment Drake's gunners burned or sank **30 Spanish ships** and destroyed thousands of tonnes of naval provisions before raiding the Algarve coast and capturing the rich Portuguese spice carrack *San Felipe* (£108,000) off the Azores. Crucially, diverting Santa Cruz's warships to hunt Drake delayed the Armada's launch by an entire vital year until 1588.

[7.4] *1587–1588*

The Logistical Shock: Seasoned Barrel Hoops, Scorched Fleets and Spanish Delay

> ***"Why did burned barrel staves and Santa Cruz's death weaken the fleet?"***

Drake's coastal raids off Cape St Vincent also inflicted hidden logistical ruin by burning huge stockpiles of seasoned **barrel staves** and hoops intended for the Armada's food and water casks. Forced to manufacture hasty replacements from damp, unseasoned green pine timber, Spanish victuallers loaded leaky barrels that warped at sea, turning salted meat, ship's biscuit, and drinking water foul. Spanish naval command weakened further in February 1588 when Madrid's most experienced fighting admiral, the Marquis of Santa Cruz, died suddenly in Lisbon. Philip II appointed the reluctant aristocratic **Duke of Medina Sidonia**—an able shore administrator who candidly protested his lack of sea combat experience and chronic **seasickness**—ordering him strictly to obey inflexible royal instructions.

[7.5] *1588*

The Enterprise of England: Medina Sidonia Assembles the Great Fleet at Lisbon

> ***"What fatal flaw undermined Philip II's plan to link Sidonia and Parma?"***

After violent spring storms forced emergency hull repairs at Corunna, the **130 ships** of Spain's Great Armada carrying roughly 30,000 sailors and soldiers entered the English Channel at the end of July 1588. Philip II's grand invasion strategy required Medina Sidonia to sail up the Channel to **Calais** and Flanders, link up with Parma's 17,000 veteran troops, and escort their barges across to Kent. Yet Philip's rigid blueprint contained a fatal structural flaw: Parma controlled **no deep-water port** in Flanders, meaning his unarmed, flat-bottomed troop barges needed forty-eight hours of calm weather to emerge through shallow coastal canals blockaded by nimble **Dutch flyboats** under Justin of Nassau, while slow courier boats prevented Medina Sidonia and Parma from timing their rendezvous.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Logistical Disruption • Drake's Preemptive Strike and the Fragility of Oceanic Staging**

Although Leicester's expedition in the Netherlands floundered, Drake's daring 1587 raid on Cadiz destroyed critical shipping and barrel staves, buying England sixteen vital months to prepare.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Was the defeat of the Spanish Armada primarily the result of superior English naval technology or catastrophic Spanish command and weather?

[8.1] *1588*

The Crescent Advances: Channel Skirmishes from Plymouth to the Isle of Wight

"Why did the Spanish crescent hold firm during Channel skirmishes?"

Sighted off the Lizard on 29 July 1588, Medina Sidonia's Armada advanced up the English Channel in a tight seven-mile **crescent formation**, stationing heavy fighting galleons on its horned wings to protect slower supply hulks in the centre. Warping out of Plymouth against the wind, **Lord Howard of Effingham**, Francis Drake, and John Hawkins seized the windward weather gauge behind the Spaniards. Over six days of running skirmishes past Plymouth, Portland Bill, and the **Isle of Wight**, agile English ships avoided Spanish grappling hooks and fired stand-off cannon salvos. Although few Spanish ships sank in the Channel, Howard prevented Medina Sidonia from seizing an anchorage in the Solent, herding the Armada onward to exposed Calais Roads on 6 August.

[8.2] *1588*

Midnight at Calais Roads: Hell-Burners, Severed Anchors and Broken Formation

"How did eight midnight fireships at Calais shatter the Spanish fleet?"

Anchored off exposed **Calais Roads** on 6 August, Medina Sidonia learned to his dismay that Parma's army at Dunkirk needed another week to embark and possessed no warships to clear Dutch blockaders. Seizing the moment around midnight on **7 August 1588**, Howard and Drake packed eight old vessels with pitch, brimstone, gunpowder, and double-shotted guns, setting these blazing **fireships** drifting on wind and tide toward the anchored Spaniards. Dreading catastrophic floating 'hell-burners' used previously against Spanish bridges at Antwerp, panic-stricken Spanish captains **cut anchor cables** in the darkness and scattered out into the open North Sea. Although not a single Spanish galleon burned that night, the Armada lost its primary heavy anchors and broke its disciplined crescent formation completely.

[8.3] *1588*

The Bloodbath at Gravelines: Hawkins' Race-Built Galleons and Close-Range Broadside

"How did race-built galleons and broadsides win at Gravelines?"

At dawn on 8 August 1588, the decisive nine-hour Battle of **Gravelines** erupted off the treacherous Flemish sandbanks. Closing to destructive cannon range of under a hundred yards aboard fast, low-built **race-built galleons** pioneered by Naval Treasurer John Hawkins, English squadrons repeatedly out-turned high-castled Spanish ships while shallow Flemish waters and Dutch flyboats barred Parma from coming out. Mounted on compact four-wheeled naval gun-carriages, long-range English bronze **culverins** fired three times faster than cumbersome Spanish guns manned by soldiers trained primarily to fire one volley and board enemy decks. Relentless English broadsides sank or drove aground five major Spanish ships, inflicted over 1,000 casualties, and permanently ruined any chance of invading Kent.

[8.4] *1588*

The Protestant Wind: The Ordeal of the Scottish Isles and Shipwrecks on Irish Rocks

> ***"Why did gales and cut anchors wreck retreating ships off Ireland?"***

Blocked by the pursuing English fleet behind them and treacherous Flemish shoals ahead, a fierce south-westerly gale—celebrated across Protestant England as the **'Protestant Wind'**—drove Medina Sidonia's battered fleet north into the open North Sea on 9 August. Critically short of cannonballs, leaking badly, and drinking putrid water from green-wood barrels, the Armada had to limp home around Scotland and **Ireland**. Uncharted North Atlantic autumn tempests turned Spain's retreat into utter catastrophe: lacking spare heavy anchors cut at Calais and guided by inaccurate charts of the Gulf Stream, over twenty-five Spanish vessels wrecked along rocky Scottish and Irish coasts where thousands drowned or were killed ashore. Barely **67 ships**—roughly half the original fleet—straggled back to Spain with over 15,000 men lost.

[8.5] *1588–1589*

The Protestant Deliverance: Elizabeth at Tilbury, Medals of Gold and English Triumph

> ***"How did Tilbury and the Armada victory secure Elizabeth's prestige?"***

Even while the shattered Armada fled north, England remained braced against Parma's army in Flanders; on 18 August Elizabeth rode in silver breastplate before 4,000 militia mustered by Leicester at **Tilbury** in Essex, famously declaring she possessed 'the heart and stomach of a king, and of a king of England too'. Victory reinforced Elizabeth's personal authority despite her gender and strengthened English Protestant national pride. Royal propaganda struck commemorative silver medals inscribed *Flavit Jehovah et Dissipati Sunt*—**'God blew and they were scattered'**—portraying Protestant England as divinely favoured. Strategically, defeating the Armada preserved Dutch Protestant independence, confirmed English **naval prestige** across the Atlantic, and ended immediate danger of Spanish conquest even as costly war dragged on until 1604.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Naval Gunfire Revolution • Race-Built Maneuverability, Fireship Disruption, and Atlantic Tempests**

Hawkins' race-built galleons and fast-reloading culverins outmatched the cumbersome Spanish fleet, while hell-burners at Calais and lethal northern gales completed the Armada's destruction.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION
How did educational expansion and popular theatrical culture transform English social and civic life?

[9.1] *1558–1588*

Humanism & The Hornbook: The Printing Press, Illiteracy and the Protestant Drive for Reading

> ***"How did Tudor hierarchy and gender shape basic literacy and schooling?"***

Sixteenth-century English education reflected humanist learning and Protestant belief that Christians should read the vernacular Bible, yet access remained sharply divided by class and gender. Overall **literacy** rose to roughly **30% of men** and **10% of women** by the end of Elizabeth's reign—concentrated overwhelmingly among gentry, merchants, and yeomen rather than rural farm labourers, whose children worked from age six. Boys of the middling sort attended elementary **petty schools** in a teacher's home to learn basic English reading, writing, and arithmetic, while some girls attended **dame schools** focused on reading, sewing, and housework. Above all, Tudor schooling aimed to reinforce the **Great Chain of Being**, teaching every child obedience to God, monarch, and social superiors.

[9.2] *1558–1588*

The Latin Grammar School: Rote Chant, Birch Rods and the Making of the Tudor Elite

> ***"How did endowed grammar schools educate gentry and merchant sons?"***

The greatest educational expansion occurred in fee-paying town **grammar schools**: forty-two were founded in the 1560s and thirty more in the 1570s by wealthy Protestant benefactors and merchant guilds, replacing dissolved monastic schools. Attended by bright boys aged ten to fourteen from gentry, professional, merchant, and yeoman families (plus talented scholarship boys), school days ran from 6 a.m. to 5 p.m. Grammar schools taught a demanding **classical curriculum** centred on **Latin** and Greek authors such as Cicero, Virgil, and Seneca alongside public rhetoric, scripture, archery, and strict corporal punishment supervised by student monitors. Meanwhile, merchants' and craftsmen's sons without Latin followed petty-to-apprenticeship routes learning practical book-keeping, commercial arithmetic, and skilled urban trades.

[9.3] *1558–1588*

Oxford, Cambridge & The Inns of Court: Gentlemen Scholars, Lawyers and Private Tutors

> ***"How did noble home tutors differ from Oxford, Cambridge, and Law Inns?"***

Children of the titled nobility were educated privately at home by prestigious **private tutors**—just as humanist scholar Roger Ascham had tutored young Princess Elizabeth. Noble boys learned Latin, Greek, French, history, philosophy, fencing, and horsemanship, whereas noble girls studied languages, music, courtly dancing, needlework, and household management to secure advantageous aristocratic marriages while remaining barred from universities. At fourteen or fifteen, wealthy gentlemen's sons progressed to **Oxford and Cambridge**, where Protestant colleges such as Emmanuel College (1584) and Jesus College (1571) expanded rapidly to train loyal, educated Anglican clergy and royal officials. Many gentry sons also studied English common law in London at the **Inns of Court** rather than entering church ministry.

[9.4] *1558–1588*

Blood Sports and Tavern Dice: Football Brawls, Cockfighting and Aristocratic Hunting

> *"How did blood sports and pastimes reflect class divides in England?"*

Elizabethan leisure pastimes were equally stratified by social rank, landownership, and gender. Only wealthy nobles and landed gentry possessed walled deer parks and legal game rights for exclusive **hunting and hawking**, fenced with rapiers, played expensive indoor **real tennis**, danced courtly galliards, composed lute music, and collected costly printed histories and classical poetry. Working husbandmen, rural labourers, and townsfolk played boisterous parish **folk football**—violent village-wide matches with few written rules, unlimited players, and frequent broken bones—and wrestled on church holy days. Yet commercial blood sports united every social class: Elizabethans from Privy Councillors down to apprentices paid pennies at Southwark's Paris Garden to gamble fiercely on **bear-baiting**, bull-baiting, and cock-fighting.

[9.5] *1558–1588*

The Elizabethan Playhouse: Commercial Theatres, Groundlings and Puritan Opposition

> *"Why did purpose-built London playhouses thrive despite Puritan anger?"*

Secular Elizabethan drama blossomed after the 1572 Vagabonds Act required touring actors to secure a nobleman's licence—producing troupes like Leicester's Men and the **Queen's Men** (1583). In 1576 actor **James Burbage** built England's first permanent purpose-built playhouse, **'The Theatre'**, in Shoreditch outside City of London jurisdiction, soon followed by the Curtain (1577) and the Rose (1587). Performances drew up to 2,000 spectators across every class: poorer **groundlings** paid just one penny to stand in the open pit around the thrust stage while wealthy gentry paid extra for cushioned gallery boxes or seats upon the stage itself. Conversely, **Puritans** and London aldermen denounced theatres for spreading bubonic plague, attracting pickpockets, and encouraging sinful idleness.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Cultural Democratisation • The Growth of Vernacular Literacy and Commercial Mass Entertainment**

The rapid rise of grammar schools and open-air commercial playhouses like The Theatre and The Rose created a common cultural language uniting nobility and groundlings across social divides.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did the Tudor state transition from brutal punishment of vagrants to institutional poor relief in the 1570s?

[10.1] *1558–1588*

The Hungry Generation: Population Explosion, Harvest Failures and Soaring Bread Prices

> ***"How did rapid population growth and bad harvests fuel food inflation?"***

Poverty and vagrancy surged dangerously across Elizabeth's reign primarily due to rapid demographic growth: England's population climbed by roughly 35%, rising from around **3 million to 4 million** people between 1551 and 1601. Major towns like London and Norwich expanded fastest while stagnant agricultural output struggled to feed extra mouths, pushing up farm rents and food prices. Rural hardship deepened sharply whenever wet weather brought consecutive **bad harvests** (especially 1573–77), causing severe grain shortages and rapid **price inflation** lingering from earlier Tudor coin debasement. With a surplus of labourers competing for scarce work, **real wages** fell sharply while the 1563 Statute of Artificers capped maximum wages, forcing landless families below subsistence.

[10.2] *1558–1588*

Enclosure and Rural Poverty: Sheep Farming, Rising Rents and Displaced Villagers

> ***"Why did enclosure and profitable sheep farming cause rural eviction?"***

Structural changes in countryside farming drove thousands more rural labourers off the land. Because raw wool and woollen cloth accounted for over **80% of exports**, profit-minded gentry landlords increasingly practiced **enclosure**—hedging open village strip-fields and shared common grazing land into private fenced pastures to expand commercial **sheep farming** rather than labour-intensive arable grain. Whereas ploughing, sowing, and harvesting corn employed whole rural parishes year-round, tending enclosed **sheep** pasture required barely one tenth the workforce while driving up entry fines (**rack-renting**) and shrinking local grain supplies. Evicted tenant cottagers and unemployed farmhands drifted toward crowded market towns—further hit whenever Spanish trade embargoes disrupted Antwerp cloth sales—swelling bands of wandering homeless rural families.

[10.3] *1558–1588*

The Fear of Vagrancy: 'Deserving Poor' vs 'Idle Beggars' and Social Anxieties

> ***"Why did authorities distinguish 'impotent poor' from 'sturdy beggars'?"***

Elizabethan society divided the poor into two distinct moral and legal categories: the **impotent poor** (or deserving poor—young orphans, widows, the elderly, sick, and disabled physically unable to work, who merited sympathetic parish charity) versus **sturdy beggars** (the idle or undeserving poor—able-bodied adults suspected of choosing criminal idleness over honest daily labour). Public anxiety over wandering masterless men was whipped up by Kent magistrate **Thomas Harman**'s popular 1567 illustrated book *A Caveat for Common Cursitors*, which exposed underworld tricks such as 'counterfeit cranks' chewing soap to fake epilepsy and 'Tom o' Bedlams' feigning madness. Lacking any salaried police force, gentry JPs feared vagrant bands spread bubonic plague, violent crime, and **rebellion**.

[10.4] *1558–1588*

Branded with the Red-Hot Iron: The 1572 Vagabonds Act and Compulsory Poor Rates

"How did the 1572 Vagabonds Act combine whipping with compulsory rates?"

Following the 1569 Northern Revolt, Parliament passed the **1572 Vagabonds Act** combining national welfare taxation with fierce physical deterrence. For the first time nationwide, local Justices of the Peace had to compile an official register of deserving poor and levy a weekly **compulsory poor rate** upon every wealthy parish householder—imprisoning anyone who refused to contribute. Simultaneously, the 1572 statute imposed harsh corporal terror upon able-bodied vagrants aged over fourteen caught begging without a JP's licence: first-time offenders were whipped naked through market towns and **bored through the ear** with a red-hot iron an inch thick; a second offence within sixty days meant hanging as a felon unless an employer hired them.

[10.5] *1558–1588*

Raw Wool and the House of Correction: The 1576 Act and the Foundations of Modern Welfare

"How did the 1576 Poor Relief Act pioneer raw wool work and Bridewells?"

By mid-decade MPs recognised a crucial shift in social attitudes: recurring cloth-trade slumps meant many able-bodied poor genuinely could not find work. The **1576 Poor Relief Act** therefore instructed town and parish officials to purchase parish stocks of **raw wool**, flax, iron, and hemp so willing unemployed residents could spin yarn and earn an honest wage. Those able-bodied vagrants who still stubbornly refused parish work were sent not to ordinary county gaols, but to newly established houses of correction known as **Bridewells** (named after London's Bridewell Palace), where inmates endured strict hard labour to reform their habits. Together, the 1572 and 1576 statutes established state responsibility for unemployment underpinning the 1601 Poor Law.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Institutional Paternalism • Compulsory Parish Taxation and Statutory Differentiation of Poverty**

Driven by terrified perceptions of roaming vagabond armies, the Elizabethan state pioneered compulsory local taxation and distinguished between the impotent and idle poor.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

How did technological navigation and oceanic privateering establish England as an emerging global maritime power?

[11.1] *1558–1575*

Navigating the Ocean Sea: Astrolabes, Magnetic Compasses and Mercator's Projection

> ***"How did astrolabes, quadrants, and Mercator maps transform navigation?"***

Elizabethan oceanic voyages depended upon major scientific advances in mathematical navigation and cartography. Mariners calculated north-south latitude far out of sight of coastlines using heavy brass **astrolabes** and more stable marine **quadrants** (or John Davis's back-staff) to measure the angle of the midday sun or Polaris above the horizon alongside translated Spanish manuals like *The Art of Navigation* (1561). Open-ocean course-plotting was revolutionised in 1569 when Flemish cartographer Gerardus **Mercator** published his cylindrical world map projection laying out parallel lines of latitude and longitude on a flat compass grid. Combined with standardized printed charts, magnetic compasses, and knotted chip logs, English captains navigated transatlantic waters with far greater precision and survival rates.

[11.2] *1558–1577*

The Race-Built Galleon: John Hawkins' Low Forecastles, Lateen Sails and Heavy Culverins

> ***"How did race-built galleons, lateen sails, and culverins improve ships?"***

Simultaneously, English royal shipyards transformed vessel engineering. Replacing slow, top-heavy medieval carracks built primarily as floating castles for boarding soldiers, Royal Navy Treasurer John Hawkins developed sleek **race-built galleons** from the 1570s: longer, narrower hulls with lowered forecastles and stern castles reduced wind drag, improved stability in Atlantic gales, and carried larger water and food stores for oceanic voyages. Combining large square main sails for downwind speed with triangular **lateen sails** on the mizzenmast for agile windward tacking, these galleons mounted heavy bronze **culverins** and demi-culverins along full-length gun decks. Capable of pounding enemy hulls from long range and reloading rapidly, race-built warships gave English explorers both oceanic endurance and formidable firepower.

[11.3] *1550s–1570s*

The Quest for Cathay: The Muscovy Company, Guinea Gold and the Northwest Passage

> ***"Why did Antwerp's collapse spur new trade companies and Arctic voyages?"***

Economic necessity drove English merchants to seek distant markets after the Antwerp cloth trade collapsed and Spanish embargoes choked traditional wool exports. Wealthy London investors pooled risk in royal chartered joint-stock companies: the **Muscovy Company** (1555) traded furs and naval timber with Russia, the Eastland Company (1579) entered the Baltic, and the **Levant Company** (1581) imported Ottoman spices and silks. Others hunted direct sea routes to Asia to bypass Iberian monopolies and acquire African gold, ivory, and enslaved cargoes (pioneered by John Hawkins in 1562). Between 1576 and 1587 **Martin Frobisher** and John Davis braved Arctic icebergs seeking a Northwest Passage above Canada, charting Baffin Island while Humphrey Gilbert promoted North American settlement.

[11.4] *1577–1580*

Around the Globe: Drake's Golden Hind, the Straits of Magellan and Nova Albion

"How did Drake navigate the Strait of Magellan and claim Nova Albion?"

In December 1577 **Francis Drake** sailed from Plymouth with five vessels and 164 men—backed secretly by Elizabeth, Walsingham, and Leicester—to raid Spanish Pacific ports and avenge Spain's 1568 treachery at San Juan de Ulúa. Surviving mutiny and ferocious storms through the **Strait of Magellan**, only Drake's renamed flagship *Golden Hind* reached the Pacific in September 1578. Sweeping north past unfortified Valparaíso and Callao, Drake captured the silver-laden *Cacafuego* before sailing up the North American coast in June 1579, where friendly Miwok people welcomed him and he claimed **Nova Albion** ('New England', likely California) for Queen Elizabeth. Crossing the Pacific, trading for cloves in the Moluccas, and rounding Africa, Drake reached Plymouth in September 1580.

[11.5] *1580–1588*

The Spoils of the Pacific: Stolen Silver, King Philip's Humiliation and Global Geopolitics

"Why was Drake's £400,000 return so significant for English sea power?"

Drake's three-year **circumnavigation** of the earth (1577–80)—only the second in world history and the first led throughout by an English captain—delivered sensational financial, political, and psychological rewards. Returning roughly £400,000 in Spanish treasure yielded syndicate investors a **4,700% profit**, while Elizabeth's Crown share exceeded an entire year's royal income and cleared England's national debt. Gathering priceless Pacific rutters and charts, signing spice treaties in the Moluccas, and proving English galleons could survive a global voyage boosted national maritime confidence and inspired Raleigh's colonial schemes in Nova Albion's wake. Conversely, Elizabeth's public **Deptford knighting** of Drake in April 1581 shattered Spain's exclusive claim to the Pacific and hastened open Anglo-Spanish war.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Cartographic Mastery • Joint-Stock Investment, Long-Range Navigation, and Global Trade Penetration**

Advances in magnetic instrumentation, race-built ship design, and chartered joint-stock ventures enabled English mariners to break Iberian trade monopolies across three oceans.

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION

Why did Walter Raleigh's attempts to establish a permanent English colony on Roanoke Island end in complete disaster?

[12.1] *1584*

The Imperial Vision: Raleigh's Royal Patent, Arthur Barlowe's Expedition and Virginia

> ***"How did Raleigh's royal patent and Hakluyt justify colonising Virginia?"***

Following the drowning of his half-brother Humphrey Gilbert, courtier **Sir Walter Raleigh** received a six-year royal patent from Elizabeth in March 1584 to explore and settle North American lands unclaimed by any Christian ruler. Forbidden by the protective Queen to sail in person, Raleigh raised £40,000 from merchants and courtiers and named the territory **Virginia** to honour the Virgin Queen. In April 1584 Raleigh sent Philip Amadas and Arthur Barlowe on a fact-finding reconnaissance to **Roanoke** Island, returning with glowing reports of fertile soil and two Algonquian men, Manteo and Wanchese. Simultaneously, clergyman **Richard Hakluyt** wrote *Discourse on Western Planting* (1584) urging Elizabeth to back Virginia as a privateering base against Spanish treasure fleets, a source of naval timber and exotic goods, and a market for English cloth.

[12.2] *1584–1585*

Mismatched Colonists: Soldiers, Alchemists, Grenville's Command and Lane's Fort

> ***"Why did recruiting 107 soldiers and gentlemen weaken the 1585 voyage?"***

For the April 1585 colonising expedition, Raleigh recruited **107 colonists**—exclusively men—aboard seven vessels commanded at sea by his fiery, aggressive cousin **Sir Richard Grenville**, with veteran army officer **Ralph Lane** appointed colony governor from ashore alongside mathematician-scientist Thomas Harriot and watercolour artist John White (whom Harriot helped learn Algonquian from Manteo and Wanchese in London). From the very outset, recruitment imbalances and divided leadership proved deeply flawed: roughly half the 107 settlers were professional soldiers and status-conscious gentlemen expecting quick gold mines or Indigenous tribute rather than skilled **farmers**, carpenters, stone-masons, and winter fishermen able to make an Atlantic wilderness colony self-sufficient, while Grenville and Lane clashed bitterly over strategy.

[12.3] *1585–1586*

Shoals and Spoiled Corn: The Tiger Wreck, Food Shortages and Secotan Hostility

> ***"How did the wreck of the Tiger ruin seed corn and force food reliance?"***

Departing Plymouth on 9 April 1585—already too late in spring to plant crops for an autumn harvest—the expedition suffered disaster on 29 June 1585 when flagship **Tiger** struck a sandbar at Ocracoke Inlet. Flooding seawater ruined almost all the hold's **seed corn**, salt, dried peas, and gunpowder, leaving the garrison unable to grow harvests or preserve meat. When Grenville sailed back to England in August for fresh supplies, Lane's 107 men at Roanoke became dangerously dependent on local Algonquians for maize and woven reed **Secotan fish traps** they could neither build nor repair themselves, while brought-over European diseases (measles or smallpox) sparked mysterious deaths and deep suspicion inside Native villages.

[12.4] *1586*

The Severed Thread: The Death of Wingina, Drake's Rescue and the First Evacuation

> ***"Why did killing Chief Wingina force Lane's colonists to flee with Drake?"***

Relations with the Secotan people deteriorated rapidly over winter 1585–86. In July 1585 Grenville had already burned the Native village of Aquascogoc over a missing silver cup; by spring 1586, exhausted by feeding unproductive English soldiers during a severe regional drought, Secotan ruler **Chief Wingina** (who took the war-name Pemisapan) stopped trading maize and coordinated local resistance. Suspecting an imminent confederate attack, Governor Ralph Lane staged a ruthless pre-emptive **1 June 1586 ambush** at Dasamonquepeuc, luring Wingina to a peaceful parley and beheading him. Surrounding Algonquian tribes cut off all food supplies; facing starvation before Grenville's delayed relief ships arrived, the colonists abandoned Roanoke on 18 June 1586 aboard **Francis Drake**'s passing fleet.

[12.5] *1587–1590*

The Lost Colony: John White's Families, the Armada Embargo and the Mystery of CROATOAN

> ***"Why did the Armada turn John White's 1587 families into a Lost Colony?"***

Learning from 1585's military mistakes, Raleigh sent artist-governor **John White** back in May 1587 with 118 men, women, and children—promised 500 acres per family—intending to settle deeper Chesapeake Bay, though their Portuguese master pilot Simon Fernandez landed them back on **Roanoke** Island, where loyal Manteo was christened Lord of Roanoke and White's granddaughter Virginia Dare was born. After hostile Algonquians killed colonist George Howe while crabbing, anxious settlers persuaded White to sail back to England for urgent supplies in August 1587. Tragically, the **1588 Spanish Armada** caused Elizabeth to requisition every seaworthy English vessel; when White finally returned in August 1590, Roanoke stood deserted with **'CROATOAN'** carved into a palisade post—ending Elizabethan America.

DISCIPLINARY CAUSAL EVALUATION **Colonial Fragility • Mismatched Colonist Skills, Severe Logistical Interruption, and Indigenous Alienation**

Unprepared aristocratic settlers, loss of seed stores during the Tiger shipwreck, hostile relations with the Secotan, and the 1588 Armada embargo doomed the first English settlement in America.

MASTER KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL QUIZ • 1558–1588

60 CORE RETRIEVAL QUESTIONS

PARTNER QUIZ OR SOLO PRACTICE: Read each question aloud. State the exact historical fact, individual, or date. Cross-check paragraph references to verify your answers. Zero marks awarded for vague generalisations.

TOPIC CARD 1 pp. 4–7 • Ref [1.1]–[2.5]

Queen, Government & The 1559 Settlement

1. In what month and year did twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth I ascend the throne?
2. Approximately how much Crown debt did Elizabeth inherit from Mary I in 1558?
3. Which European financial exchange lent money to the English Crown at 14% interest?
4. Whom did Elizabeth appoint as her trusted Principal Secretary on her accession day?
5. How many senior advisors sat on Elizabeth's executive Privy Council?
6. Which English continental outpost in France was lost in January 1558?
7. What title did Elizabeth assume under the 1559 Act of Supremacy?
8. What fine was imposed under the 1559 Act of Uniformity for failing to attend Sunday church?
9. What liturgical book was made compulsory in all English parish churches in 1559?
10. What official visitations were launched in 1559 to enforce the Royal Injunctions?

TOPIC CARD 2 pp. 8–11 • Ref [3.1]–[4.5]

Religion Challenges, Recusancy & Mary Stuart

11. What term describes devout English Catholics who refused to attend Anglican church services?
12. How many London preachers were suspended by Archbishop Parker in the 1566 Vestments Crisis?
13. In which Spanish Netherlands town was an English Catholic seminary college established in 1568?
14. Which Spanish commander led 10,000 veteran troops (tercios) into the Netherlands in 1567?
15. In what month and year did Mary, Queen of Scots flee across the Solway Firth into England?
16. In which fortified castle in the Yorkshire Dales was Mary Stuart first held under custody?
17. What scandalous documents were presented at the 1568 York Inquiry accusing Mary of murder?
18. At which house outside Edinburgh was Lord Darnley murdered in February 1567?
19. Which Scottish Protestant earl led the rebel lords who forced Mary's abdication at Lochleven?
20. Why did Elizabeth refuse to pass a definitive guilty or innocent verdict at the Westminster Inquiry?

TOPIC CARD 3 pp. 12–13 • Ref [5.1]–[5.5]

Northern Rebellion, Plots & Mary's Execution

21. Which two Catholic Northern Earls led the November 1569 Northern Rebellion?
22. In which northern cathedral did the rebel Earls tear up English prayer books and celebrate Mass?
23. Approximately how many northern rebels were executed under martial law by royal order in 1570?
24. What papal bull was issued by Pope Pius V in February 1570 excommunicating Elizabeth?
25. Which Italian banker orchestrated an international Catholic conspiracy to invade England in 1571?
26. Which high-ranking English peer was executed on Tower Hill in June 1572 for his role in the Ridolfi Plot?
27. What 1584 pledge bound English subjects to execute anyone plotting against Elizabeth's life?
28. Which young Catholic conspirator used hidden beer-barrel ciphers to communicate with Mary Stuart in 1586?
29. Who served as Elizabeth's ruthless Spymaster that cracked the Babington ciphers?
30. In which Northamptonshire castle was Mary, Queen of Scots beheaded on 8 February 1587?

TOPIC CARD 4 pp. 14–17 • Ref [6.1]–[7.5]

Cold War with Spain, Privateering & War

31. What lucrative commercial licenses granted courtiers exclusive rights to trade specific goods?
32. What Spanish cargo ship carrying 26 tons of silver bullion was seized by Francis Drake in 1579?
33. What was the name of Drake's flagship in which he completed his 1577–1580 global circumnavigation?
34. At which royal dockyard did Queen Elizabeth knight Francis Drake aboard his ship in April 1581?
35. Approximately how much plunder did Drake return to the English treasury following his voyage?
36. What 1584 secret treaty allied Philip II of Spain with the French Catholic League against Protestants?
37. What August 1585 treaty committed Elizabeth to send 7,400 English troops to the Netherlands?
38. Which royal favourite was appointed commander-in-chief of English forces in the Low Countries?
39. In which Spanish harbour did Francis Drake launch his daring preemptive raid in April 1587?
40. How many Spanish warships and supply vessels did Drake destroy during the "singeing of the King's beard"?

TOPIC CARD 5 pp. 18–19 • Ref [8.1]–[8.5]

The Spanish Armada Campaign of 1588

41. Who was appointed Commander-in-Chief of the Spanish Armada following Santa Cruz's death?
42. How many ships and troops made up the Spanish Armada when it sailed from Lisbon in May 1588?
43. Which Spanish general commanded the 30,000 veteran invasion army stationed in the Netherlands?
44. On what date was the Spanish Armada first sighted off the Lizard and Plymouth?
45. What tactical defensive crescent formation did the Armada maintain while sailing up the Channel?
46. What naval weapon did the English deploy at midnight off Calais on 7 August to break the crescent?
47. Which decisive naval battle was fought on 8 August 1588 between English and Spanish fleets?
48. What name was given to the north-westerly gale that blew the retreating Armada into the North Sea?
49. Where did Queen Elizabeth deliver her famous speech declaring she had "the heart and stomach of a king"?
50. Approximately how many Spanish ships were destroyed or wrecked along the coasts of Scotland and Ireland?

TOPIC CARD 6 pp. 20–27 • Ref [9.1]–[12.5]

Society, Poverty, Exploration & Virginia

51. What wooden board with alphabet and Lord's Prayer protected by animal horn was used in petty schools?
52. Which prestigious legal institutions in London provided gentlemen with courtly and legal education?
53. Name the first purpose-built London playhouse, erected by James Burbage in Shoreditch in 1576.
54. What term described the open pit yard where poorer Elizabethan playgoers stood for a penny?
55. What agrarian process fenced off common arable land for sheep farming, dispossessing rural labourers?
56. Which 1572 statute introduced whipping, ear-boring, and compulsory parish poor rates for vagrants?
57. What 1576 statute established Houses of Correction (Bridewells) to put the able-bodied poor to work?
58. What technological navigational instrument allowed Elizabethan sailors to calculate latitude at sea?
59. Which courtier and explorer was granted a royal patent by Elizabeth in 1584 to colonise North America?
60. What mysterious single word was found carved into a wooden post at the abandoned Roanoke colony in 1590?